

3.1 Windows XP: Step-By-Step Installation

3.1.1 Planning The Installation

Before you start installing Windows XP, you need to make sure your computer meets XP's minimum system requirements: a 233 MHz Intel or AMD processor, 64 MB of RAM, 1.5 GB of free hard disk space, a Super VGA (800 x 600) or higher resolution video adapter and monitor, a CD-ROM or DVD-ROM drive, and a compatible mouse and keyboard. These are the *bare minimum* system requirements, and XP will work better if you have a more powerful system.

Here's a checklist of what you need to do before starting the installation:

- m Check the system requirements
- m Check compatibility of your hardware with XP. Also, if you're planning to install a particular piece of software, check if it is compatible. For the hardware check, you can view the HCL (Hardware Compatibility List) on Microsoft's Web site; the Windows XP CD, too, has a text file that tells you what hardware is compatible. As for software, you'll need to check the packaging or the manufacturer's Web site for XP compatibility.
- m Determine the hard disk partitioning options—keep at least 1.5 GB for the Windows XP partition, though we recommend some more
- m Choose the appropriate file system: FAT, FAT32, or and NTFS (FAT is usually selected if you have a hard disk smaller than 2 GB.)

3.1.2 Beginning the installation

You can install Windows XP in many different ways, depending on your needs and limitations. Installation can be manual or unattended. You can do a manual installation in several ways:

- m Boot from CD—here, no existing hard disk partition is required.
- m Boot from the six setup boot disks, and then insert the CD (if booting from CD is not possible)—here, too, no existing partition is required.